



One for the ages: After 36 all out and without Virat Kohli and Mohammed Shami, Rahane's composed 112 in Melbourne absorbed Australia's attack, restored belief and sparked India's remarkable turnaround.

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was injured. The series looked all but over.

Rahane didn't respond with a stirring speech.

He responded the only way he knew, by quietly taking responsibility.

His hundred at the MCG settled a dressing room that had been shaken by Adelaide. Over the next three Tests, India pieced together one of the greatest overseas triumphs in its history, culminating in that unforgettable afternoon at the Gabba.

Even then, Rahane never made the story about himself. He was happiest talking about the collective, about resilience, about a dressing room that refused to give up.

"The Australia series was really special, we all know that. That series was very close to my heart. Representing the country is obviously a huge deal and also defeating Australia in such circumstances was really special," he said.

There was another side to Rahane's game that rarely received the attention it deserved. Standing in the slip cordon, he was among India's safest hands for more than a decade.

Whether it was Ravichandran Ashwin weaving his magic at home or Mohammed Shami and Jasprit Bumrah finding the edge overseas, Rahane became the team's trusted catcher. He finished with 109 catches in Tests, but the number alone doesn't tell the story. Many came at defining moments, often off thick outside edges on lively pitches. Others were sharp chances that demanded quick reflexes.

In an Indian team blessed with world-class bowlers, Rahane quietly ensured their hard work wasn't

wasted. Like so much else in his career, he made one of the toughest jobs on the field look routine.

Statistics will remember Rahane for 5,077 Test runs, 12 hundreds and one of India's greatest overseas triumphs as stand-in captain.

Those who knew him, though, may remember something else.

A Mumbai boy who believed turning up early was a sign of respect. A senior who insisted that the cap mattered. A teammate who never chased headlines, only the next training session. A cricketer who kept believing, even when the phone stopped ringing.

For nearly two decades, Rahane kept turning up: at Shivaji Park, at the Wankhede, at Lord's, at the MCG and at the Gabba. Sometimes as India's vice-captain, sometimes as a discarded domestic cricketer still waiting for one more chance.

The final India cap never came. Everything else remained unchanged.